

group, where Anand Mahindra tried building kabaddi with the company's tractor dealers as franchisees. It failed to scale. Later, after looping in his brother-in-law and sports commentator Charu Sharma, the two incorporated Mashal Sports and began chasing something bigger.

As Mahindra has said in several public media interactions, his own connection to the sport went back decades, including fond memories of playing kabaddi at Lawrence School, Ooty.

He has also credited Sharma with reviving his interest in the sport after Sharma covered kabaddi during the 2006 Doha Asian Games.

Further, a conversation with former NBA International President Heidi Ueberroth turned the idea into a real plan. She convinced him that kabaddi was suited for TV audiences and that got the ball rolling on PKL.

Getting a broadcaster was the hardest. Mashal Sports had a 10-year rights deal from the International Kabaddi Federation, but every network it approached for years said no; some even suggested it would have to pay to get kabaddi aired.

Star India was the only one willing to step up, though the initial broadcasting fee was not substantial.

Convincing owners was another uphill battle. In earlier media interactions, Mahindra has said most initial franchise owners invested "purely out of friendship" rather than any belief that the sport could be monetised.

Mashal Sports kept entry costs low so that, if the experiment failed, the damage to franchise owners would be limited.

But what came next surprised

THE STORY OF PKL

In 2014, when the Pro Kabaddi League (PKL) was launched, kabaddi barely existed as a business

By 2026, PKL had become India's second most-watched sports league, as per a KPMG report, ahead of hockey and football

Star India went as far as buying 74% of Mashal Sports after PKL's first season, making the broadcaster the majority owner of the league it aired

By its fifth season, PKL made its next big bet: expanding from eight teams to 12, and from 60 matches a season to well over 130

PKL's franchise economics were built to be low-risk from Day One



everyone. Even Mahindra later admitted that he had not envisioned the game acquiring such scale and popularity so quickly.

BUILDING THE SPECTACLE

Apurv Gupta, currently Head of Contract Sports at Capri Sports and CEO of Bengal Warriorz, joined Star India in 2013, a year before PKL was launched, and later headed the league's operations before moving to Bengal Warriorz.

Gupta recalls that the broadcaster had no real inhibitions. "I think when you're trying to do something new, there is always risk. But there was utmost commitment from Star India," he says.

"Star India had a vision to develop indigenous sports and domestic sports in India and backed that vision with its platform and its money," he adds.

Star India went as far as buying 74% of Mashal Sports after PKL's first season, making the broadcaster the majority owner of the league it aired. Mahindra and Sharma kept the remaining 26%.

Most new Indian leagues grow cautiously. PKL did not. "It wasn't, let's go slow, let's try and build it step by step," Gupta told *BT*. "It was, let's do a big bang, and that's what helped."

Star India threw its main channels and broadcast budget behind the launch, and Season 1 delivered almost immediately: PKL claims to have had 435 million viewers, more than the Hockey World Cup and FIFA World Cup combined that year.

Part of that success, Gupta argues, came from the sport being unmistakably Indian.

"There was a lot of nostalgia among audiences, as everybody had played kabaddi at some point, back in their school days."